it gave for these SDPs and did not install a big bureaucracy (like other Western aid agencies including USAID and DFID) that went about monitoring these funds. Operational flexibility in the aid sector, apart from increasing goodwill, gave India some political weight in Afghanistan. All this was made possible by Karzai, who warmly welcomed India's presence in the country despite initially being wary of New Delhi's closeness with the United Front.

'Maximum Leader'

With the Taliban ousted, arguably, there was no reason for the partisans and the conciliators to compete over policy output after 2002. Supporting the new Kabul government in its developmental endeavors would have been enough. Fine in theory, exercising such neutrality was practically difficult in Afghanistan's factionalised polity. Just as former President Najibullah had the Khalq, the Mujahideen, and Pakistan as enemies, Hamid Karzai too had adversaries within and outside the government.[50] Ranging from senior members of the former UF, Rome, Cyprus, and Peshawar groups to the various Taliban factions that soon reemerged from bases in Pakistan, Karzai had many rivals. As Narayanan put it, Karzai was a 'maximum leader' in country that, despite the world's desire, did not function as a democracy.[51] Karzai had, indeed, manipulated Afghanistan's domestic politics along pro-Karzai and anti-Karzai lines. While the US supported him, Pakistan, despite recognising his presidency, openly supported the Taliban (and, ironically, even lobbied support of former UF leaders against Karzai over the years). India, however, began weighing its odds despite its big-ticket aid projects in Afghanistan.

In the early months of his rise, a militia-less Karzai was unknown to New Delhi. This was despite the fact that he had obtained a Masters in Political Science from the Shimla University from the north Indian state of Himachal Pradesh in 1984 (during the peak of the anti-Soviet jihad), understood Indian culture and sensitivities well, and had engaged with Nambiar in the early 1990s (after which India had lost touch with him). While Indian policymakers began highlighting Karzai's fondness for India based on his educational background in subsequent years, policy mandarins in New Delhi were wary of his geopolitical